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Legislature approves $2.5 billion to recovery from wildfires

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On Jan. 23, Governor Gavin Newsom signed two bills appropriating $2.5 billion to help fund the recovery efforts in the Los Angeles area after the devastation caused by multiple wildfires. The burning began Jan. 7. The Governor's press release described the damage as hurricane-force fire storms.

This was only 10 days after he made the request of the current Legislative Special Session. Both bills, ABx1-4 and SBx1-3, provide more than $2.5 billion for disaster relief and were passed unanimously.

"Thanks to our partners in the legislature, we're providing over $2.5 billion in immediate relief – expediting initial firestorm response and recovery efforts," Newsom said in the release. "We're also directing millions of dollars to help local governments speed up building approvals – so folks can rebuild their homes faster."

As of Jan. 25, Cal Fire reported that the various Los Angeles area fires have caused 28 fatalities and burned and destroyed more than 16,000 structures.

Nearly all of the $2.5 billion is intended to expedite the initial response and recovery efforts. These funds would help offset costs associated with the emergency protective measures, evacuations, sheltering for survivors, debris removal and cleanup, post-fire hazard assessments (such as flash flooding and debris flows), traffic control, and other necessary emergency response activities.

There is a separate $5 million appropriation for rebuilding. The Department of Housing and Community Development will receive $4 million for local governments in the fire areas. This will be used for additional planning review and building inspection resources to expedite building approvals during the recovery period.

Another $1 million is targeted at fire-damaged school facilities. Its purpose is to aid the school districts to rebuild damaged structures. The funding will provide technical assistance to Los Angeles Unified School District, Pasadena Unified School District, and charter schools affected by the fires.

"The money will come from the state's reserve fund dedicated to economic uncertainties, which had about $8.3 billion as of Jan. 10, according to H.D. Palmer, spokesperson for California's Department of Finance," Cal Matters reported.

"This money is moving immediately and was approved unanimously with bipartisan support," said Jesse Gabriel, chair of the Assembly's Budget Committee. "It's the first of many steps and there will ge a lot of steps in this journey.

Besides seeking the Legislature's approval of supplement funding to help the victims and the recovery, Newsom has issued a number of Executive Orders to address the problems of the victims and the local jurisdictions' recovery efforts.

These include providing tax relief to those impacted by the fires; suspending permitting and review requirements under the California Environmental Quality Act and the California Coastal Act to streamline rebuilding homes; fast-tracking temporary housing; prohibiting landlords in Los Angeles County from evicting tenants for sharing their rental with survivors displaced by the fires; mobilizing debris removal and cleanup; allowing expert federal hazmat crews to start cleaning up properties; hastening efforts to remove debris, bolster flood defenses, and stabilize hillsides in affected areas; mitigating the risk of mudslides and flooding; safeguarding survivors from price gouging; getting student back to the classroom; and protecting victims from real estate speculators..

"California leaders from both political parties are united and working together to provide L.A. with the immediate assistance and support they need," Assembly Speaker Robert Rivas (D-Salinas) said in the release. ". . .. This is a first step, but we are committed to a full recovery and will stand with Angelenos until this work is done.

"It is very meaningful for me as legislator for Southern California to see people of parts of the state stand up and say, 'We'll be with you'," Gabriel also said in his statement.

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